

Travellers and goods arriving in Australia can introduce exotic pests, diseases and weeds. This could harm our health, environment and commercial industries.

Check our [current traveller alerts](#). These include tips on how you can reduce risks before you arrive in Australia.

You can also visit [human health](#) for advice on:

- yellow fever vaccination requirements
- bringing human remains back to Australia.

Current alerts

What is the risk?

Foot-and-mouth disease (FMD) is a highly contagious viral disease of animals and is one of the most serious livestock diseases. It affects cloven-hoofed animals, such as cattle, sheep, goats and pigs.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

An outbreak of FMD could devastate Australia's livestock industries, affect the economy and threaten jobs. An incursion of this disease would lead to a loss in production of meat and milk, cessation of trade and may require the slaughter of many animals order to control the disease.

Goods that present a risk

- meat and meat products
- dairy products
- shoes, boots and clothing
- camping equipment, including backpacks
- mountain bikes and other sporting equipment that have been used in rural areas, markets and zoos or near susceptible animals, and have soil or manure attached
- any equipment used with livestock.

Treatment

You should clean your shoes, clothing and equipment thoroughly before you travel to Australia.

Clean your shoes:

- Shake/scrape shoes to remove loose contamination such as soil, manure and plant matter
- Thoroughly wash soles, laces, velcro and external surfaces using soap/detergent, water and a brush
- Dry well and double check all traces of contamination are removed. Repeat procedure if ANY contamination remains visible.

Following these steps will help to reduce the risk, however you **MUST** still declare on your Incoming Passenger Card if you have visited a rural area or been in contact with, or near, farm animals. Your shoes may then be inspected by a biosecurity officer at the airport and further treatment may be required. There are no penalties for truthfully declaring or disposing items before undergoing biosecurity screening.

Top tip: If your shoes are dirty and/or you have visited a rural area, consider thoroughly cleaning your footwear or leave them behind.

Any goods that present an unacceptable level of biosecurity risk will be managed, and may require treatment at your expense, in accordance with the Biosecurity Act 2015.

Measures

- Don't bring meat or dairy products to Australia. If you do, you **MUST** declare them for inspection.
- Ensure any shoes, clothing or equipment you are bringing into Australia are clean and free from soil and manure.
- Declare on your Incoming Passenger Card if you have visited a rural area or been in contact with, or near, farm animals.
- Declare truthfully on your Incoming Passenger Card, and present anything that you have declared to a biosecurity officer for inspection when you arrive in Australia.
- Avoid farms and livestock for the first seven days after arriving in Australia.

Penalties apply for breaching Australia's biosecurity laws. Your visa may also be cancelled and, if so, you will be refused entry into Australia and you may not be able to return to Australia for up to three years.

Download

[Foot-and-mouth disease factsheet \(PDF 387 KB\)](#) [Foot-and-mouth disease factsheet \(DOCX 216 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

For further information visit [Foot-and-mouth disease](#).

What is the risk?

African swine fever is a highly contagious viral disease of pigs. It is one of the most serious livestock diseases, with high mortality rates in infected pigs. There is no vaccine or cure.

The virus can survive for many weeks, even months, in raw, cured and cooked meats, and on objects such as vehicles, equipment, footwear and clothes.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

An outbreak of African swine fever could devastate Australia's livestock industries. It could cost the economy billions of dollars and thousands of jobs.

Goods that present a risk

- fresh, dried, and preserved meat products and dairy products
- shoes, boots and clothing used on farms, in rural or wilderness areas, markets, zoos or near susceptible animals
- camping equipment, including backpacks
- mountain bikes and other sporting equipment
- animal skins, hunting trophies, horns or bones that have not been properly cleaned/treated.

Treatment

You should clean your equipment thoroughly before you travel to Australia. If you bring goods that have soil and manure, they may require treatment.

Measures

- do not bring meat products to Australia.
- you must declare on your IPC if you have visited a rural area or been in contact with, or near, farm animals in the past 30 days.
- declare and present anything that represents a possible African swine fever risk to a biosecurity officer for inspection on arrival in Australia.

For further information visit [African swine fever](#).

What is the risk?

Imported plants and their products can introduce exotic pests and diseases.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

If these pests and diseases establish in Australia, they could have a devastating impact on our agriculture and unique environment.

Goods that present a risk

- Betel leaves
- Mustard stick (inflorescence stalks)

New maximum inspection weight limits

From 1 August 2023, the following weight limits will apply to fresh betel leaves and fresh mustard stick quantities arriving in Australia through airports and seaports or as mail:

Product	New maximum inspection weight limits
Betel leaves	500 grams

Mustard stick (inflorescence stalks) 500 grams

If you bring betel leaves or mustard stick over these new weight limits to Australia, you will need to arrange for the goods to be inspected at an Approved Arrangement site before they can be released. The offsite inspection will be undertaken at your expense. If you do not wish to have the goods inspected, you can voluntarily dispose of the goods or you can pay for the goods to be exported. A biosecurity officer will be able to explain these options and related fees to you.

Consignments mailed to Australia over these new weight limits will be exported or destroyed.

All other import conditions as outlined on the department's Biosecurity Import Conditions system (BICON) for [Piper betel leaves](#) and [mustard stick](#) will remain unchanged. This includes the requirement for each consignment to arrive with a valid phytosanitary certificate and be clean and free of biosecurity risk material.

Measures

To minimise delays, additional costs and to prevent your goods from being exported or destroyed, don't bring or mail quantities weighing more than 500 grams. If travelling, declare it and present the entire amount to a biosecurity officer for inspection when you arrive in Australia. If mailing, pack the goods in clean, new and secure packaging and complete the postal declaration label accurately for inspection.

What is the risk?

Birds, poultry meat and poultry products can carry serious diseases, including bird flu (avian influenza), exotic strains of Newcastle disease and infectious bursal disease.

Bird flu (or avian influenza) is a highly contagious disease of poultry. It is caused by a virus, some strains are highly lethal.

Newcastle disease is one of the most serious of all infectious bird diseases. It is a devastating virus that can spread rapidly.

Infectious bursal disease (IBD) is a highly contagious viral disease of domestic fowl. The virus can remain infective in the environment for long periods and is resistant to many disinfectants.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

Newcastle disease has the potential to kill thousands of bird species. It could severely damage Australia's egg, chicken, bird meat and aviary industries.

Harmful strains of bird flu affecting parts of Asia in recent years could devastate the Australian poultry industry and harm native bird populations.

Highly virulent IBD is a serious threat to production in commercial poultry flocks.

Goods that present a risk

When travelling to Australia from overseas, you **MUST** declare for inspection:

- any poultry meat and products (including raw or cooked chicken and duck)
- fresh or preserved eggs or egg products (including all whole, dried and powdered eggs)
- mooncakes containing egg, and egg products such as mayonnaise
- egg products including noodles and pasta that are not commercially manufactured
- feathers and items containing feathers, bird nests, stuffed birds, bird cages, poultry vaccines
- any other animal products, plant material and certain food.

Treatment

Poultry meat and products are not allowed into Australia and will be forfeited to the Commonwealth and destroyed.

Other goods will be inspected and may be returned to you, sent for treatment or exported at your expense or forfeited to the Commonwealth and destroyed. Check that you can bring the item back before travelling, refer to the [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#).

Measures

- When travelling to Australia from overseas, don't bring poultry meat and products. If you do, you **MUST** declare for inspection.

For further information visit the [Avian Influenza \(Bird Flu\)](#) section. The [Department of Health and Aged Care](#) website provides further information on bird flu including latest news and an information hotline.

What is the risk?

The black spined toad has the potential to cause more damage to Australia's environment than the cane toad.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

The black spined toad is not present in Australia and needs to be kept out.

Goods that present a risk

Toads are active at night and often feed on insects in well-lit areas before seeking a shelter to rest in during the day. Shoes and other equipment that are left outside overnight are a favoured hiding location for toads.

Measures

- Check your shoes and other items for potential stowaways.
- If you find a toad treat it carefully, as they have poisonous skin toxins. Use gloves but if you have to handle it with bare hands, use an antiseptic hand wash afterwards.
- If you do happen to find a toad in your luggage once you have arrived home, place it in a secure container and call us on 1800 798 636. Do not release it into the environment or dispose of it in any other way.

What is the risk?

There are a number of infectious diseases of concern to the Australian population which can lead to severe illness and death.

Treatment

If you are feeling unwell:

- before travelling to Australia, please see a doctor prior to travel
- during your flight to Australia, please tell a crew member
- when entering Australia, please let a biosecurity officer at the airport know.

Measures

Border measures are in place to manage travellers who are feeling unwell coming into Australia.

To find out more, visit the [Department of Health and Aged Care's website](#).

What is it?

Didymo (*Didymosphenia geminata*) is a cool, freshwater algae that forms thick mats which smother river beds.

It can have a significant environmental impact and limit the use of the waterways for recreational activities.

Equipment used in fresh water, such as fishing lines, canoes, and waders pose a serious risk of carrying the 'Didymo' algae.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

Didymo is almost impossible to eradicate and takes just a single live cell to establish and spread. While not present in Australia, it has invaded rivers and lakes in Europe, Asia, North America and New Zealand.

Didymo is made up of cells that cannot be seen with the naked eye until a large colony is formed. Special care is therefore required when bringing equipment into Australia that has been used in fresh water overseas.

Goods that present a risk

Didymo can survive in damp conditions and is often carried on items such as:

- fishing equipment – rods, reels, bags, rope, nets, knee guards, gaiters and waders
- recreational and water sport equipment – wetsuits, neoprene socks, waterskiing and wakeboarding equipment, buoyancy vests, watercraft, paddles, spray decks, spray skirts, soft foam handles, hiking gear and swimwear.

Treatment

All items exposed to overseas freshwater rivers, lakes and streams must be thoroughly cleaned to remove any algal clumps, and be completely dried for inspection in Australia.

Goods and equipment not complying with these requirements or those goods that cannot be inspected to verify that they are clean and completely dry will be required to undergo mandatory treatment.

Options for didymo treatment are limited and an external commercial treatment provider may be required. Commercial treatment is at your expense and may take several weeks.

Where treatment is not possible, goods may be forfeited to the Commonwealth and destroyed, or exported at your expense.

Measures

If you bring any items exposed to overseas freshwater rivers, lakes and streams into Australia, ensure they are thoroughly cleaned and dry, and free of reservoirs of water.

Declare and present all freshwater equipment to a biosecurity officer for inspection when you arrive in Australia.

Top Tip: Hire equipment when overseas to avoid treatment costs and delays.

What is the risk?

The biosecurity risks associated with the importation of timber and wooden goods include:

- infestation with insects or snails
- contamination with soil, bark, plant material, animal residues and/or seeds
- disease pathogens.

Other damaging pests that could threaten our biosecurity include Asian longhorn beetle, burnt pine longicorn beetle, Japanese pine sawyer beetle, Asian gypsy moth, termites, auger beetle, powder post beetles and wood wasps.

Bark presents a risk as it may carry disease spores and/or mask the presence of insects.

Why is it a problem for Australia?

If these pests and diseases establish in Australia they could have a devastating impact on our agriculture and forestry industries, natural environment, food security and economy.

Goods that present a risk

When travelling to Australia from overseas, you **MUST** declare all wooden articles including antiques, toys, instruments, statues, carvings, picture frames and wooden artefacts on your IPC.

All timber and wooden related articles must be inspected by a biosecurity officer before being permitted into Australia.

Treatment

If biosecurity concerns are found during the inspection, a biosecurity officer may direct you to treat the goods (at your own cost) following which they will be returned to you. Goods that cannot be treated will be forfeited to the Commonwealth and destroyed.

Measures

- Ensure all wooden articles that you are importing are clean and free of bark, timber insects, soil or other contaminants.
- Look closely for holes and sawdust as this may mean that your wooden article contains insect pests.
- Declare it and present all wooden articles to a biosecurity officer for inspection when you arrive in Australia.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/travelling/to-australia/advice-to-travellers>